

assertion of a shared South American identity, expressed by the creation of a vast new South American state. This was to be Gran Colombia, which embraced an immense area of northern South America, essentially the modern states of Ecuador, Colombia, Venezuela, and Panama.

Bolívar's vision of an independent South America consistently fell foul of a series of political realities. His military successes—for example, in 1824, the routing of the remaining Spanish strongholds in Peru, when his armies attacked from the north and the south in a pincer movement in the Central Andes—proved impossible to translate into enduring and stable states.

Bolívar was an idealist and a passionate opponent of slavery. He considered that so disparate a land and a people could only be ruled by a strong central government. Seeing himself as its natural leader, he proposed himself as the lifelong president of Gran Colombia. This provoked predictably bitter opposition.

Gran Colombia breaks up

By 1830—the year Bolívar died, aged 47, of tuberculosis—Gran Colombia had already broken up. Arguably, it was the result of the kind of nationalism already surfacing in Europe, with the independence of Greece and, the following year, of Belgium. More particularly, it was due to a failure to agree on the future of Gran Colombia. There were disputes over

“May slavery be banished forever together with the distinction between castes.

José Morelos

Leader of the failed

Mexican Revolt of 1813–1815

whether its government was to be liberal, conservative, or authoritarian. Venezuela, in particular, was subjected to bitter wars throughout the 19th century that cost the lives of an estimated 1 million people.

This lack of direction resulted in instability and a social inequality that would persist for a century or more. It would also produce a series of authoritarian military leaders acting in the interests of the landowners. An inevitable consequence was a persistently oppressed underclass, urban and agricultural, black and white. The *hacienda*—vast acres inefficiently worked by armies of peasants in the interests of a complacently cruel, land-owning elite—dominated.

In 1910, Mexico descended into another revolution. This was partly a result of being wrenched between ineffectual liberal regimes that sought to alleviate the obvious suffering of the poor but did little to address fundamental economic weaknesses, and self-serving authoritarian regimes that cared more for bombast than real reform.

Bolívar's visions of a recast, independent South America could never contend with the reality of an unequal society that shared no common belief in its own destiny and that was consistently the victim of competing, mostly violent efforts to assert special interests. ■

The Battle of Ayacucho

(1824) saw the defeat of the Spanish army at the hands of the South American liberation troops. It marked the end of Spanish rule in Peru and in South America.

